

Late Deliveries, Lost Customers

Why Olist customers give bad reviews, and what to fix first

Analysis for the Head of Operations

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14.6%

of reviewed orders end in a 1-2
star review: 14,382 of 98,330

Broken delivery promises and incomplete orders account for the avoidable bad reviews; completeness is the larger lever

SITUATION

14.6% of reviewed orders get 1-2 stars, although 93.2% of deliveries arrive on or before the promised date.

COMPLICATION

Late and undelivered orders are 9.5% of orders but 42.7% of bad reviews. A second problem hides inside the on-time figure: orders with several items are recorded as delivered while part of the order is missing.

RECOMMENDATION

First make every order complete and measurable. Then fix transit on the Rio de Janeiro and Northeast routes, and warn customers before a promise is missed.

42.7%

of bad reviews come from the 9.5% of orders that were late or never delivered

81%

of complaints about on-time orders with several items report a missing part

1,609

bad reviews avoidable in the base case (1,072 to 2,145), 11% of the total

One in seven reviewed orders ends in a bad review, although 93% of deliveries keep the promised date

The question from the Head of Operations

Why do customers give bad reviews, how much does it cost the business, and what should we fix first?

How cost is measured here. The data contains no commission or cost figures, so the cost of the problem is counted in bad reviews, not in money.

99,092

orders placed

13.5M

BRL, value of products ordered (GMV)

93.2%

of deliveries on or before the promised date

2.9%

of orders never delivered

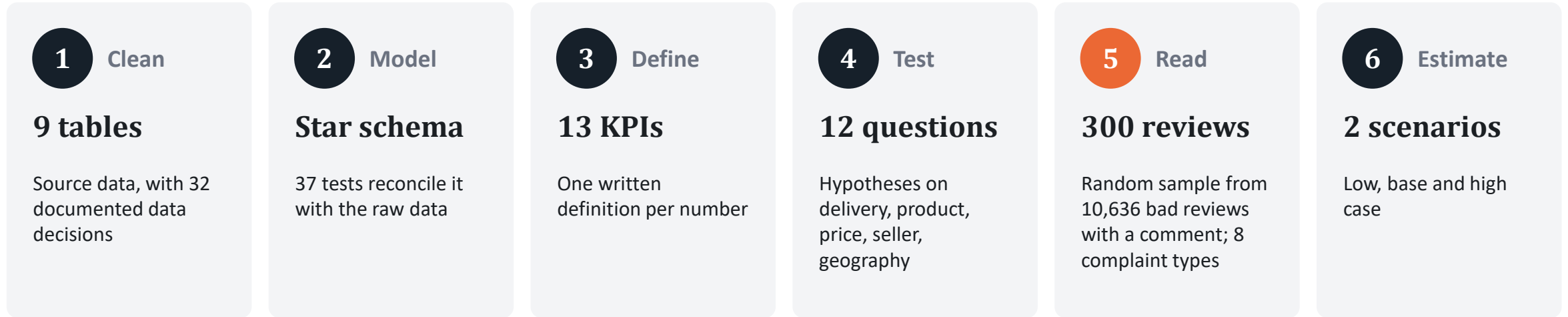
4.09

average review score, out of 5

14.6%

of reviewed orders with 1-2 stars

The analysis combines 99,092 orders with 300 customer reviews read in the original Portuguese



Three choices that shape the results

Orders that never arrived stay in the analysis

They are 2.9% of orders and 15.0% of bad reviews.

Late means after the promised calendar date

A delivery on the promised day counts as on time.

One review per order

When an order has several reviews, the latest one counts.

A broken delivery promise is the strongest driver: 62% of late orders get a bad review, against 9% of on-time orders



9.5% of orders

were late or never delivered, and they account for 42.7% of all bad reviews

50.9 to 55.6 points

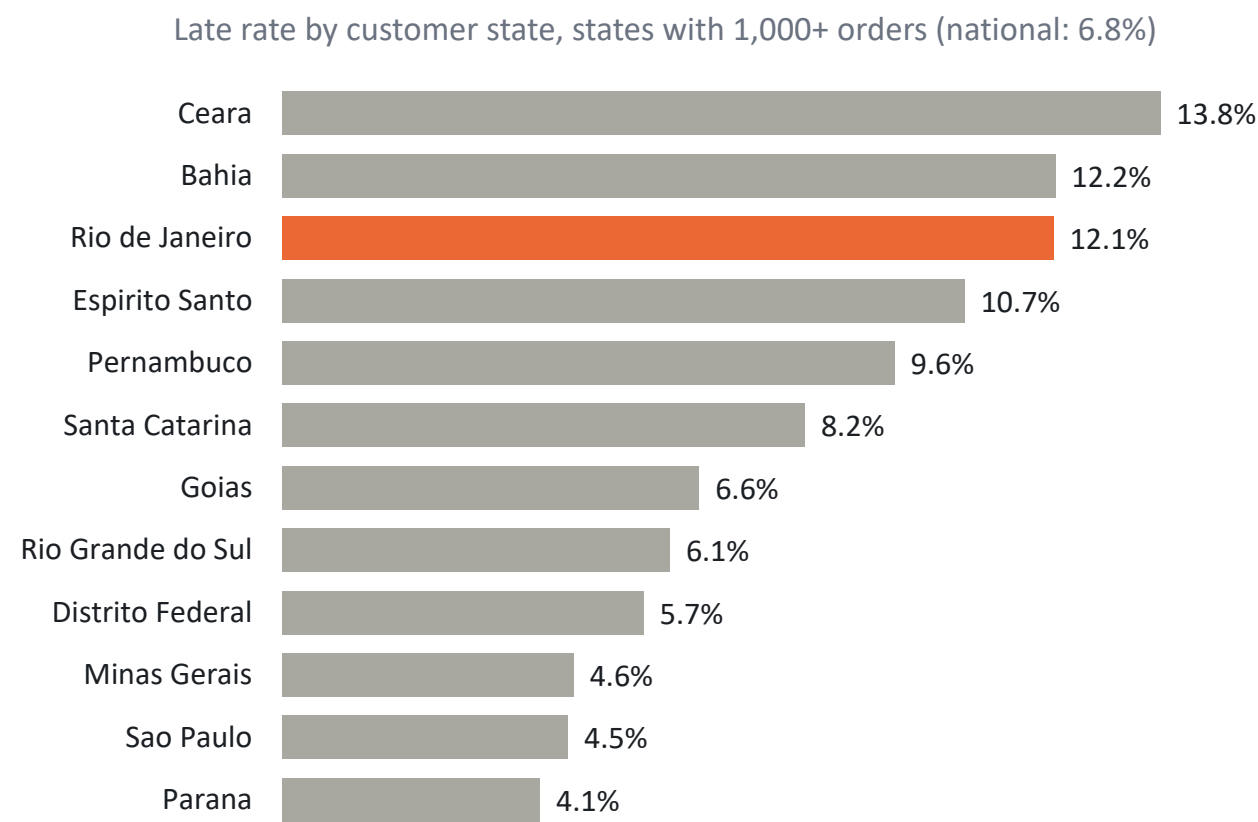
gap between late and on-time orders in every one of the five regions

0.86 correlation

between the monthly late rate and the monthly share of bad reviews, over 20 months

Observational data: a strong and consistent association, not a proven effect.

The delay arises in transit on specific routes, above all to Rio de Janeiro and the Northeast, not with a few bad sellers



22.9%

of all late deliveries go to Rio de Janeiro, which has 12.9% of orders

26 vs 7 days

median time with the carrier: late orders vs on-time orders

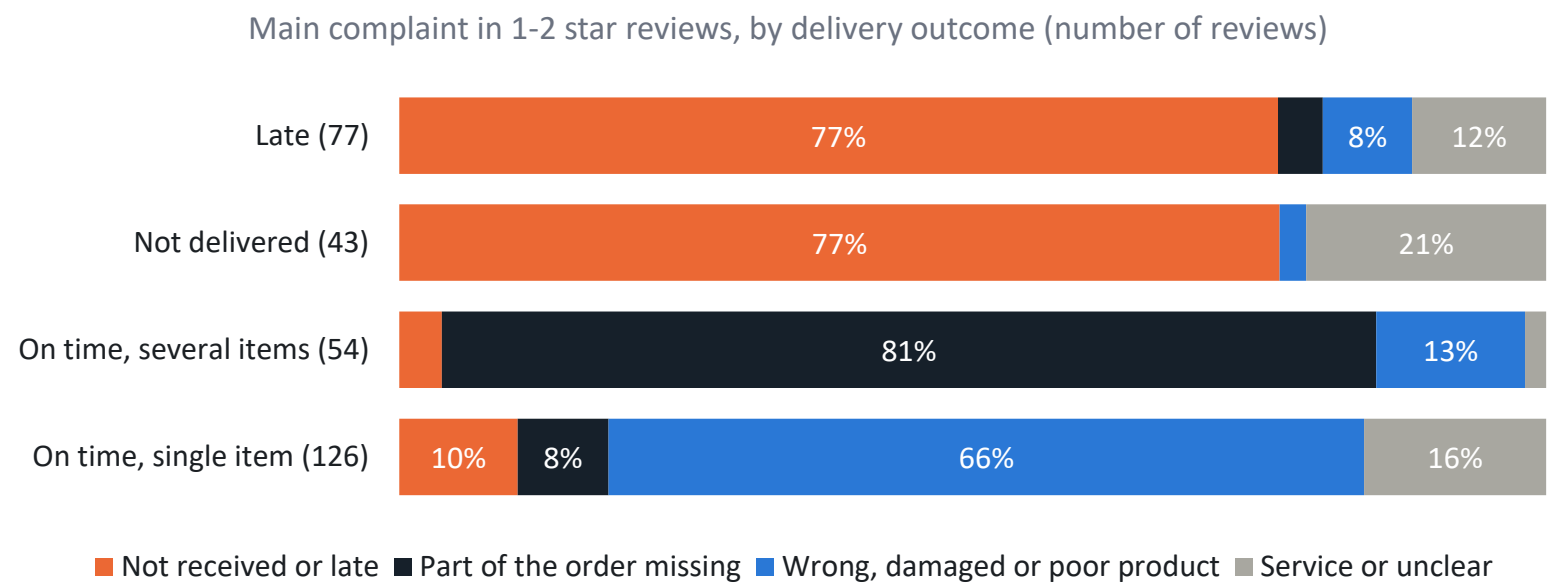
72%

of late orders were handed to the carrier in time by the seller

15%

of late orders come from the worst 10% of sellers (64 sellers with 30+ orders)

Late customers write "not received"; customers with several items delivered on time write "part of my order is missing"



81%
of complaints about on-time orders with several items say that part is missing (95% interval 69% to 90%)

66% of late-order complaints say the order has not arrived: the review is written while waiting.

"The order arrived before the deadline, but when I opened the box it was incomplete. I ordered two sets and only one came."

Customer review, translated. Order: on time, several items

"I still have not received my order. It was going to be a gift and the birthday was yesterday."

Customer review, translated. Order: late

"I received only one item and it is already marked as received on the website, and the shop does not answer."

Customer review, translated. Order: on time, several items

Complete orders and on-time delivery in the five worst states could remove about 1,600 bad reviews, 11% of the total



14.6% to 13.0%

share of 1-2 star reviews in the base case
(12.4% to 13.5%)

23.6%

of bad reviews is the ceiling for any action on
late deliveries alone, if no order were late

Read this as an order of magnitude. The scenario applies observed differences between groups of orders. It is not a measured effect, and the data has no cost side.

Start with order completeness, then transit on the worst routes, and warn customers before a promise is missed

1 Make every order complete, and measure it

9,096 on-time orders with several items get 24.6% bad reviews, against 7.5% for single items.

Impact **High: about 1,151 bad reviews (768 to 1,535)**

Effort Medium

Owner Seller Operations

First step Audit 100 several-item orders marked delivered: sent later, or never sent?

2 Fix transit to Rio de Janeiro and the Northeast

Five states hold 1,079 late orders above the national rate; late parcels spend 26 days in transit, not 7.

Impact **Medium: about 457 bad reviews (305 to 610)**

Effort High

Owner Logistics

First step Build a carrier scorecard by route; review the promised dates there.

3 Warn customers before a promise is missed

Bad reviews go from 32% at 1-3 days late to 68% at 4-7 days; 66% of late complaints are written while waiting.

Impact **Not quantified: needs a test**

Effort Low

Owner Customer Service

First step Send a new delivery date to half of the at-risk orders and compare the reviews.

Effort levels and owners are assumptions: Olist's costs and organisation are not in the data.

The findings are strong associations, not proven effects; four next steps would turn them into a business case

LIMITATIONS

No experiment. Nobody was assigned a late delivery at random; hidden factors can play a role.

The survey is sent around the promised date. Late customers are asked while still waiting, which sharpens the gap.

300 reviews, one coder. Only customers who wrote a comment are represented.

No cost or commission data. Impact is counted in reviews, not in money; no return on investment.

NEXT STEPS

- 1 Audit several-item orders.** Does the missing part arrive later, or is it never sent? The fix differs.
- 2 Test proactive messages.** A random half of at-risk orders gets a new date; compare the reviews.
- 3 Add carrier and cost data.** Needed to rank routes by return, not only by late rate.
- 4 Analyse the 2,881 undelivered orders.** They are 15.0% of bad reviews and outside both scenarios.